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Falling

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'I'm rather alarmed at the idea that thinking might end up being like the destructive seizure that had St Paul falling off his horse. In the same way that a sudden gust of wind and the pitching of a boat can send us sprawling across the deck. A slap in the face, a sharp, heavy blow, exactly applied, which makes the body unsettled, makes it lose its balance, and draws our attention to the proximity of death.'

'And at that point something other begins.' (Serres 1995: 33)

St Paul's fall is such a shocking experience that we use the expression 'road to Damascus experience' to identify those unanticipated life-changing events which, in drawing our attention to death, reawaken us to life. It is not something that we anticipate in the everyday. Catherine Cl'ment opens her book of falls, *Syncope: The Philosophy of Rapture*, with the example of epilepsy, a fall as dramatic as St Paul's, but one, in its fearfulness, possibly closer to home. Epilepsy is a fainting and falling that, long ago, was regarded as a divine experience: one fell, the prey of a god or spirits, and emerged, a new person (Cl'ment 1994: 1-11). And the sacred associations still attach to this experience, despite the rationalist repressions of a secular order. Living from day to day without knowing when the next fit will take them, epileptics must daily experience a frightening passivity that intimates the awesome and dreadful workings of the divine in our lives.

> In love everything changes, and continues changing all the time. There is no ' stopped clock

> What do I mean when I say that I have my head in the clouds? ' As I begin to feel lighter than
 4)

Vertigo

By Caravaggio - Self-scanned, Public Domain, Link

> Very often they seemed to leave my body as light as if it had lost all its weight, and some

> _Saul arose from the ground; and when his eyes were opened, he could see nothing; so they l

> _And ... something like scales fell from his eyes and he regained his sight._ (_Acts 9_)

Magical Falling

> And then she noticed a certain confusion among the cavalrymen. One of them had somersaulted

> _I remembered vividly having known a similar sort of felicity in a car while it rained and v
 113)_

> It is a commonplace of ethnography that early, 'primitive' art forms were meant to tempt to
 walls at Lascaux are solicitations: they would draw the opaque and brute force of the 'therene
 human into the luminous ambush of representation and understanding. (1989: 138-9).

Involuntary Memory

> But it is sometimes just at the moment when we think that everything is lost that the intimate minded state I had failed to see a car which was coming towards me; the chauffeur gave a shout, stones in front of the coach-house. And at that moment when, recovering my balance, I put my foot down (9)

> The sun was shining on a row of trees that followed the railway line, flooding the upper half of the

> Every moment is two moments. (Michaels 1997: 140)

> A moment in the past, did I say? Was it not perhaps very much more: something that, common to

On the Road

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